SDG 15.2.6

SDG 15 Life on Land

Sustainable management of land for tourism

Mariano Marcos State University · THE Sustainability Impact Ratings 2027

The question *Offer educational programme/outreach for local or national communities on sustainable management of land for tourism.*

1 · Introduction

MMSU's commitment is to take an active role in protecting and promoting sustainable use of terrestrial ecosystems, responsible land use, and biodiversity conservation. Farm tourism takes shape: rice paddy art, an approved farm-tourism model, a native-tree learning park and a protected-area communication plan.

2 · Body

2.1 · Rice Paddy Art Brings Visitors to MMSU's Farm-Tourism Demonstration Fields



Unveiling of the 2025 rice paddy art featuring CHED Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis and her ACHIEVE agenda, MMSU Extension Demonstration Area, 22 August 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)



Rice paddy art featuring Dingras as the Rice Granary of Ilocos Norte, MMSU Dingras Campus, unveiled 9 September 2025. (Photo: MMSU STRATCOM)

In partnership with the Department of Agriculture–Philippine Rice Research Institute (DA-PhilRice), Mariano Marcos State University held the ceremonial transplanting of its eighth annual rice paddy art on July 7, 2025, at the Extension Demonstration Area near the Twin Gate of the Batac campus, and unveiled it on August 22, 2025. The design, featuring CHED Chairperson Shirley C. Agrupis and her ACHIEVE agenda, was realized with the PalayCheck System, the Carrageenan Plant Growth Regulator, and two rice varieties, purple rice (IR 1552) and green rice (NSIC Rc222). About 50 BS Agriculture students, with MMSU extension and research staff and PhilRice, served as guides and transplanters. MMSU President Virgilio Julius P. Manzano Jr. said the paddy art "attracts visitors, promotes research, and showcases innovation," and Extension Director Dr. Marilou Lucas described it as a statement of commitment to agri-tourism, research and rice appreciation.

On September 9, 2025, the MMSU Dingras Campus unveiled its second rice paddy art, featuring Dingras as the Rice Granary of Ilocos Norte, created by MMSU student planters with PhilRice Ilocos Norte and the Local Government Unit of Dingras. Initiated in 2024, the Dingras paddy art is aligned with Republic Act 10816, the Farm Tourism Development Act, and CAFSD Dean Dr. Charlie B. Batin commended it for boosting agro-tourism and enrolment in agriculture programmes.

Resources: 1, 2, 3

2.2 · DOST-PCAARRD and UP-ISSI Assess MMSU's Proposed TALON Farm Tourism Project

Ongoing programme · site visit of January 15, 2026



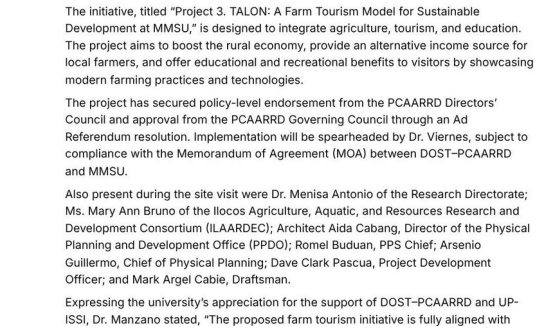
DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site

By Wimbledon Bosque

Officials from the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST–PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP-ISSI) conducted a site visit at the Mariano Marcos State University (MMSU) Crops Research Laboratory on January 15 to assess the proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program.

The delegation, led by Assistant Professor Melanie Moraga-Leaño, Director of UP-ISSI and SciCAT Program Leader, together with UP-ISSI extension specialists Kaye Bravo-Coballes, Janelle Faye Tanudtanud, Joshua Garcia, and Garry Nipales, along with Dianne Cabello of the Technology Transfer and Promotion Division, DOST–PCAARRD, was welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius Manzano, Jr.

Capture: MMSU News, 20 January 2026, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site" (headline and opening paragraphs).



The initiative, titled "Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU," is designed to integrate agriculture, tourism, and education. The project aims to boost the rural economy, provide an alternative income source for local farmers, and offer educational and recreational benefits to visitors by showcasing modern farming practices and technologies.

The project has secured policy-level endorsement from the PCAARRD Directors' Council and approval from the PCAARRD Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution. Implementation will be spearheaded by Dr. Viernes, subject to compliance with the Memorandum of Agreement (MOA) between DOST–PCAARRD and MMSU.

Also present during the site visit were Dr. Menisa Antonio of the Research Directorate; Ms. Mary Ann Bruno of the Ilocos Agriculture, Aquatic, and Resources Research and Development Consortium (ILAARDEC); Architect Aida Cabang, Director of the Physical Planning and Development Office (PPDO); Romel Buduan, PPS Chief; Arsenio Guillermo, Chief of Physical Planning; Dave Clark Pascua, Project Development Officer; and Mark Argel Cabie, Draftsman.

Expressing the university's appreciation for the support of DOST–PCAARRD and UP-ISSI, Dr. Manzano stated, "The proposed farm tourism initiative is fully aligned with

Capture: the same article, on Project 3 TALON and the approval of the PCAARRD Governing Council.

On January 15, 2026, officials of the Department of Science and Technology–Philippine Council for Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development (DOST-PCAARRD) and the University of the Philippines–Institute for Small-Scale Industries (UP-ISSI) visited the MMSU Crops Research Laboratory to assess a proposed farm tourism project under the Science for the Convergence of Agriculture and Tourism (SciCAT) Expansion Program. The delegation, led by UP-ISSI Director and SciCAT Program Leader Asst. Prof. Melanie Moraga-Leaño, was welcomed by MMSU President Virgilio Julius P. Manzano Jr. and guided through an on-site technical walkthrough by MMSU's Vice President for Research, Development and Innovation, the Director for Research, Innovation and Technology, the dean of the College of Business, Economics and Accountancy, and project members from its Department of Tourism and Hospitality Management led by Dr. Eva Jean Viernes. Planners of the Physical Planning and Development Office and the Ilocos Agriculture, Aquatic and Natural Resources Research and Development Consortium (ILAARRDEC) also took part.

The project, "Project 3. TALON: A Farm Tourism Model for Sustainable Development at MMSU," is designed to integrate agriculture, tourism and education. It aims to boost the rural economy, provide an alternative income source for local farmers, and offer educational and recreational benefits to visitors by showcasing modern farming practices and technologies. The project has the endorsement of the PCAARRD Directors' Council and the approval of the PCAARRD Governing Council through an Ad Referendum resolution, and its implementation, led by Dr. Viernes, is subject to the memorandum of agreement between DOST-PCAARRD and MMSU. MMSU is among the select institutions developing science-and-technology-based agri-tourism hubs under SciCAT, which turns farms into tourism sites to promote innovation, entrepreneurship and community development.

Resources: 4

2.3 · Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park Is Enriched with 28 Native Tree Species

Ongoing programme · since 2023

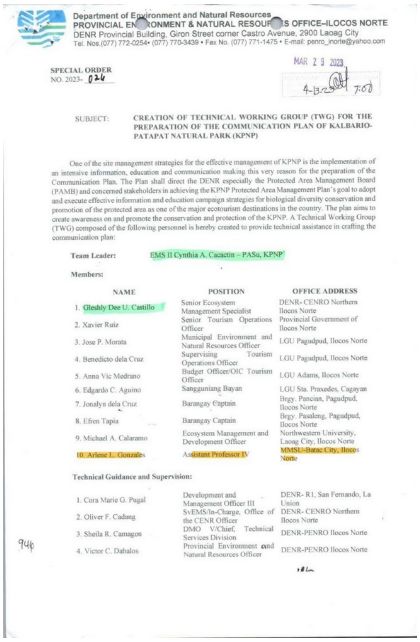
On January 13, 2023, MMSU planted 120 more seedlings of 28 native tree species and two bamboo species at the Biodiversity Conservation Learning Center and Leisure Park on the Main Campus, led by then President Shirley C. Agrupis with administrators, faculty, staff and students. The park is used as a field laboratory for classes and was identified for development into a health and wellness tourism hub, a plan endorsed by the provincial government and aligned with the Health and Wellness Complex of the College of Medicine.

The planting continues a tradition that began in 2017 with the Green Wall project on the Batac campus and extends to the Nagbacsan site and the Currimao, Dingras and Laoag campuses, as the university's contribution to the provincial "Green Wall of Ilocos Norte" and the National Greening Program of the Department of Environment and Natural Resources.

Resources: 5

2.4 · MMSU Expert Serves on the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park Technical Working Group

Ongoing role · appointment of 29 March 2023



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SPECIAL ORDER
NO. 2023- 024

MAR 29 2023

SUBJECT: CREATION OF TECHNICAL WORKING GROUP (TWG) FOR THE PREPARATION OF THE COMMUNICATION PLAN OF KALBARIO-PATAPAT NATURAL PARK (KPNP)

One of the site management strategies for the effective management of KPNP is the implementation of an intensive information, education and communication making this very reason for the preparation of the Communication Plan. The Plan shall direct the DENR especially the Protected Area Management Board (PAMB) and concerned stakeholders in achieving the KPNP Protected Area Management Plan's goal to adopt and execute effective information and education campaign strategies for biological diversity conservation and promotion of the protected area as one of the major ecotourism destinations in the country. The plan aims to create awareness on and promote the conservation and protection of the KPNP. A Technical Working Group (TWG) composed of the following personnel is hereby created to provide technical assistance in crafting the communication plan:

Team Leader: EMS II Cynthia A. Cacactin – PASu, KPNP

Members:

NAME	POSITION	OFFICE ADDRESS
1. Gleshly Dee U. Castillo	Senior Ecosystem Management Specialist	DENR- CENRO Northern Ilocos Norte
2. Xavier Ruiz	Senior Tourism Operations Officer	Provincial Government of Ilocos Norte
3. Jose P. Morata	Municipal Environment and Natural Resources Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
4. Benedicto dela Cruz	Supervising Tourism Operations Officer	LGU Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
5. Anna Vic Madriano	Budget Officer/OIC Tourism Officer	LGU Adams, Ilocos Norte
6. Edgardo C. Aguino	Sangguniang Bayan	LGU Sta. Praxedes, Cagayan
7. Jonalyn dela Cruz	Barangay Captain	Brgy. Pancian, Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
8. Efren Tapia	Barangay Captain	Brgy. Pasaleng, Pagudpud, Ilocos Norte
9. Michael A. Calaramo	Ecosystem Management and Development Officer	Northwestern University, Laoag City, Ilocos Norte
10. Arlene L. Gonzales	Assistant Professor IV	MMSU-Batac City, Ilocos Norte

Technical Guidance and Supervision:

1. Cora Marie G. Pagal	Development and Management Officer III	DENR- R1, San Fernando, La Union
2. Oliver F. Cadang	SvEMS/In-Charge, Office of the CENR Officer	DENR- CENRO Northern Ilocos Norte
3. Sheila R. Camagon	DMO V/Chief, Technical Services Division	DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte
4. Victor C. Dabalos	Provincial Environment and Natural Resources Officer	DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte

Document: DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024 (29 March 2023) naming Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU to the KPNP Technical Working Group.

Through DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, dated March 29, 2023, Dr. Arlene L. Gonzales of MMSU was named a member of the Technical Working Group that prepares the Communication Plan of the Kalbario-Patapat Natural Park (KPNP), a protected area in Ilocos Norte. The group, led by the KPNP Protected Area Superintendent, brings together DENR offices, the Provincial Government of Ilocos Norte, the LGUs of Pagudpud and Adams in Ilocos Norte and Sta. Praxedes in Cagayan, barangay officials and Northwestern University.

The Communication Plan supports the goal of the KPNP Protected Area Management Plan to adopt and carry out effective information and education campaigns for biological diversity conservation and for the promotion of the protected area as a major ecotourism destination.

Resources: 6

3 · Conclusion

Rice paddy art draws visitors to demonstration fields with students as guides. A farm-tourism model, a native-tree park and a role in a natural park's communication plan point the same way: tourism built around agriculture, learning and conservation.

4 · Resources

1. MMSU News, "CHED Chairperson Agrupis to be featured in MMSU-PhilRice paddy art," 8 July 2025. https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2472/ched-chairperson-agrupis-to-be-featured-in-mmsu-philrice-paddy-art
2. MMSU News, "2025 Rice Paddy art features CHED Chair Agrupis," 22 August 2025. https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2527/2025-rice-paddy-art-features-ched-chair-agrupis
3. MMSU News, "Dingras campus launches rice paddy art," 12 September 2025. https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2560/dingras-campus-launches-rice-paddy-art
4. MMSU News, "DOST-PCAARRD, UP-ISSI visit proposed MMSU farm tourism project site," 20 January 2026. https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/article/news/2869/dost-pcaarrd-up-issi-visit-proposed-mmsu-farm-tourism-project-site
5. MMSU News, "More trees planted at MMSU to establish 'health tourism' hub," 13 January 2023. https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/news/more-trees-planted-at-mmsu-to-establish-health-tourism-hub
6. DENR-PENRO Ilocos Norte Special Order No. 2023-024, 29 March 2023 (MMSU SDG 15 page). https://www.mmsu.edu.ph/resources/1TCpM-DxbkgfOh4QGwlfVr8QavCchKWKu/data